

The Poor Man's **XP Mode**



In a perfect world, all software would be free and you could work on whatever system you chose. However, reality is always stranger than fiction, and a certain operating system called Windows, made by Microsoft Corporation, almost always prevents you from switching to GNU/Linux.

A bewildering majority of Linux users dual-boot between Linux and Windows. There are many reasons for this, the most common of which is corporate software. Almost all major companies use custom software, which typically run only on Windows. Another major cause is that Microsoft refuses to take any action against those who use 'unlicensed' and 'non-legitimate' copies of Windows. The fact of the matter is, Windows is here to stay (at least for a while), and there's nothing that can be done about it.

Of all the versions of Windows, Windows XP is still the preferred one for most of the world's population. No other OS can run as many applications as XP. Windows Vista was a disaster partly because it couldn't run a lot of older apps. In fact, rather than beef up compatibility, Windows 7 launched something called XP Mode for all its enterprise and 'enthusiast' versions—Windows 7 Professional and Ultimate.

As Microsoft states, it had no choice because the immensely long shelf life of Windows XP

enabled a huge amount of software to be developed for it, most of which is incompatible with the current Windows NT 6 architecture. Microsoft has made sure XP Mode is available only for the enterprise versions—for offices running corporate software that are incompatible with NT6. However, the idea behind XP Mode is not novel—it's being put to good use in many other places.

XP Mode: What is it?

In its most basic form, XP Mode is a para-virtualised, fully licensed copy of Windows XP Professional with Service Pack 3 running on Windows 7. With hardware-assisted virtualisation becoming available to the masses via AMD-V and Intel VT-x, a para-virtualised Windows XP makes perfect sense. At the cost of only a 15 per cent performance drop compared to the native performance, the latest version of Windows is able to run all the apps that could run on Windows XP.

However, XP Mode isn't available for everyone. Windows 7 Home Premium